
Read the center before choosing a wing

THREE QUESTIONS

Which pawn contact can open the position? Which side has a lead in development? Where are the kings? Answer those questions before deciding whether to attack on the kingside, queenside or in the center.

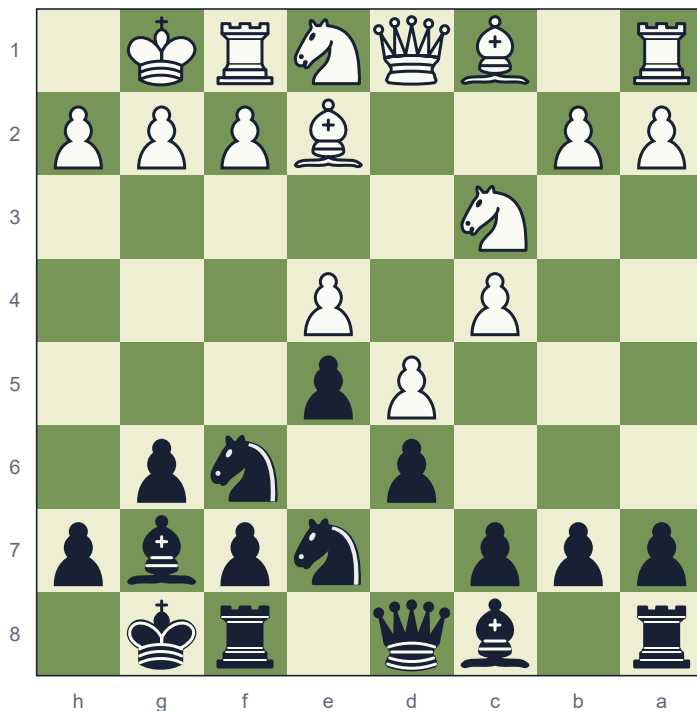
USE THE DIAGRAMS ACTIVELY

For each diagram, name Black's worst piece and White's strongest useful reply. Write one plan and the pawn break that makes it possible. A plan is a sequence of decisions, not a promise to play the same moves against everything.

THE DIAGRAMS ARE LEGAL COURSE POSITIONS

These positions come from the checked repertoire. Some are White to move; the lesson still asks you to understand Black's plan after White's reply. The caption always gives the actual side to move.

The locked Classical chain



Black to move | from 03-01

DIAGNOSE

White's d5/e4 chain faces Black's d6/e5 chain. Neither d-pawn can move straight forward. The chain gives a direction to the plans, but either side can open it with a pawn lever.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Prepare ...f5 by moving the f6 knight and coordinating the pieces. If ...f4 fixes the center, use the gained space to bring pieces toward the king.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White expands with c5 and may invade on the c-file. White can also undermine the attack with g4. Count how many moves your pieces need.

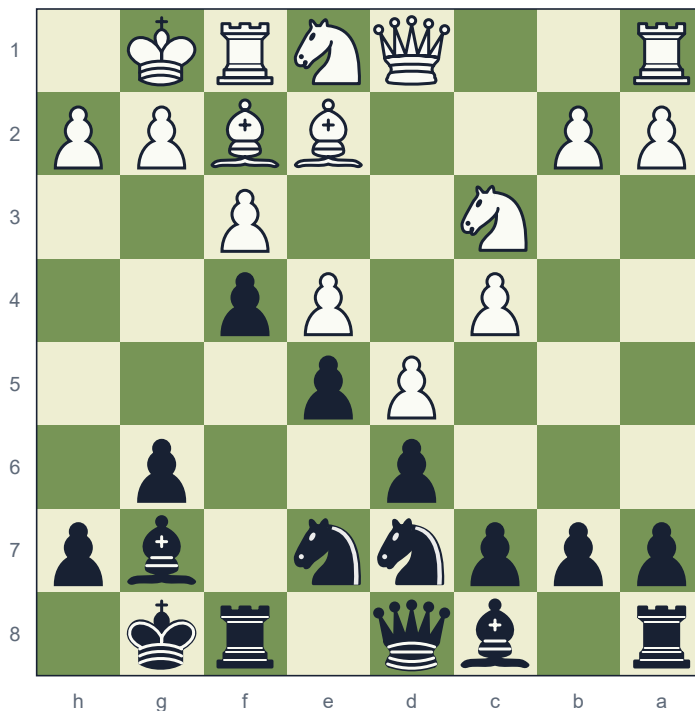
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Which knight must move before ...f5, and what is White's fastest central or queenside reply?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

After ...f4: space is not a mating attack



Black to move | from 03-01

DIAGNOSE

The f4 pawn gains space and restricts White's pieces. It also fixes targets and closes lines your own rooks might otherwise use.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Support the pawn with ...g5 only if the pieces can join. Typical jobs include ...Ng6, ...Nf6, ...h5 and queen access. Identify the entry square, not just the next pawn.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may play c5, g4, or bring defenders to f2 and d3. If the attack slows, the queenside weaknesses can become decisive.

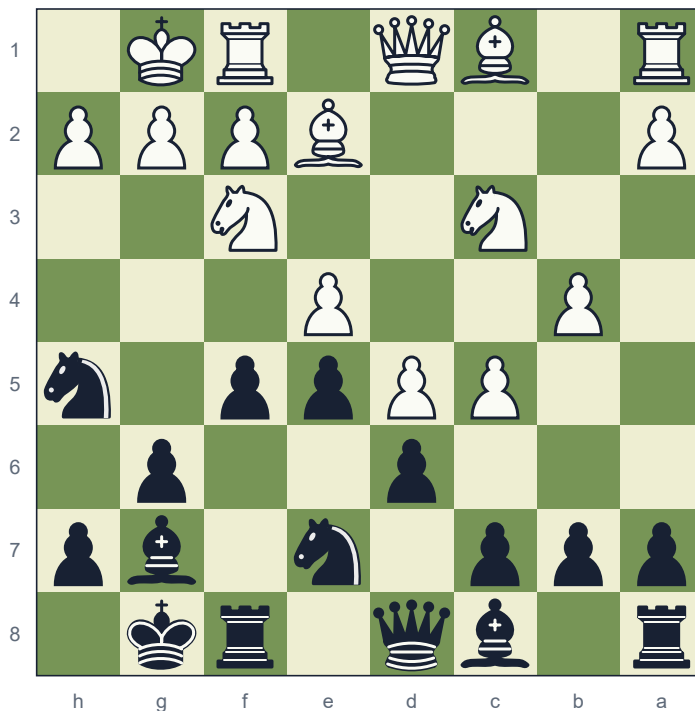
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Name the first piece that should join the attack and the line it will use.

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

The Bayonet: two simultaneous pawn contacts



DIAGNOSE

White's c5 attacks d6 while Black's f5 attacks e4. The locked center can open from either end, so a one-wing evaluation is incomplete.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Compare ...f4, ...fxe4 and a d-pawn exchange only after analyzing White's captures. Preserve piece activity if the pawn skeleton changes.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White can trade on d6 or f5 and use open files before Black finishes regrouping.

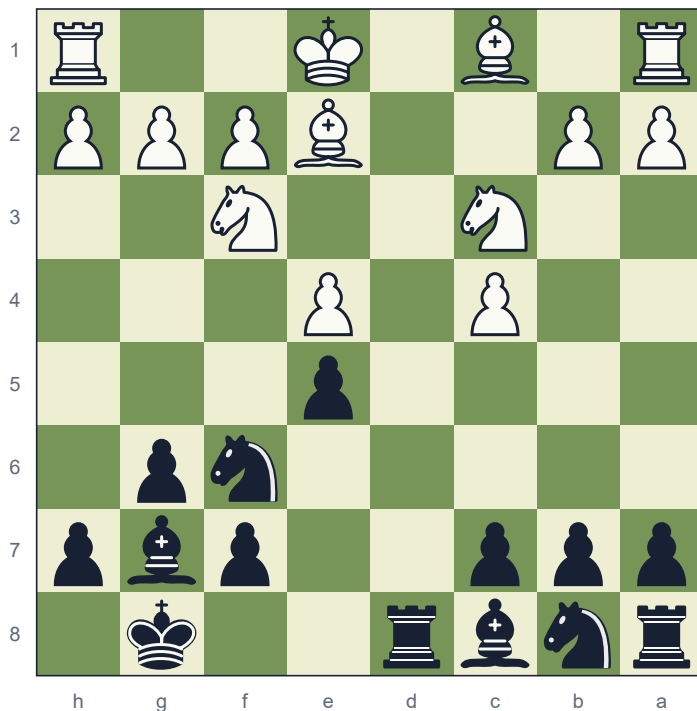
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Which captures can change the center immediately, and what file opens after each?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

The open d-file after an exchange



White to move | from 06-01

DIAGNOSE

Both d-pawns have left the d-file, and the queens are gone. A direct mating race has been replaced by piece coordination and control of d4 and d5.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Develop the remaining pieces and contest the d-file. Keep e5 defended, especially if a bishop pins Nf6. A rook on an open file needs support and entry squares.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may invade d5 with a knight or double rooks. A passive black bishop can be worse than a small pawn weakness.

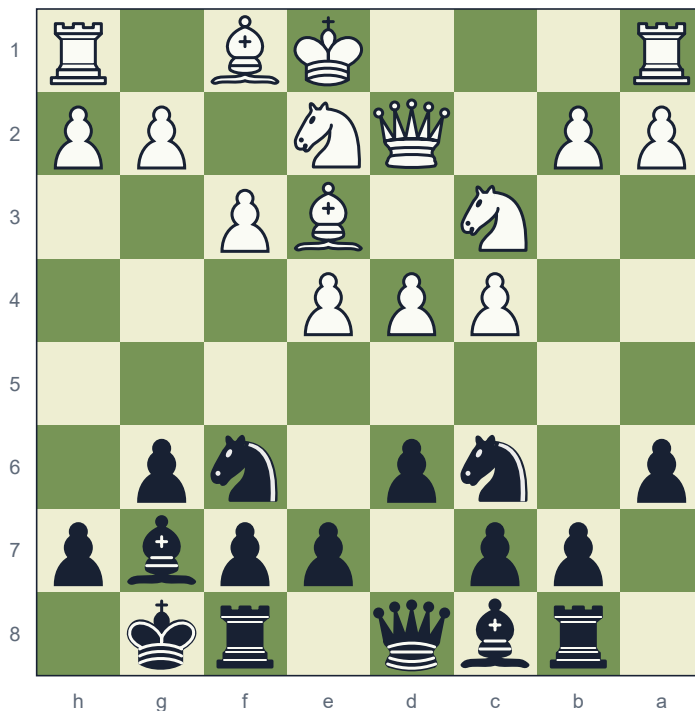
THINK BEFORE MOVING

What would make a rook trade favorable, and which minor-piece square must you control?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

Panno: the queenside break



White to move | from 09-01

DIAGNOSE

Black has ...Nc6, ...a6 and ...Rb8. White's f3 pawn supports the center but delays natural king-knight development.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Prepare ...b5 when the captures work. If White restrains it with a4, compare ...e5. If White closes with d5, answer the knight attack first.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

Bh6, h4 and g4 can threaten the king. White may avoid long castling and turn the queenside opening into a central game.

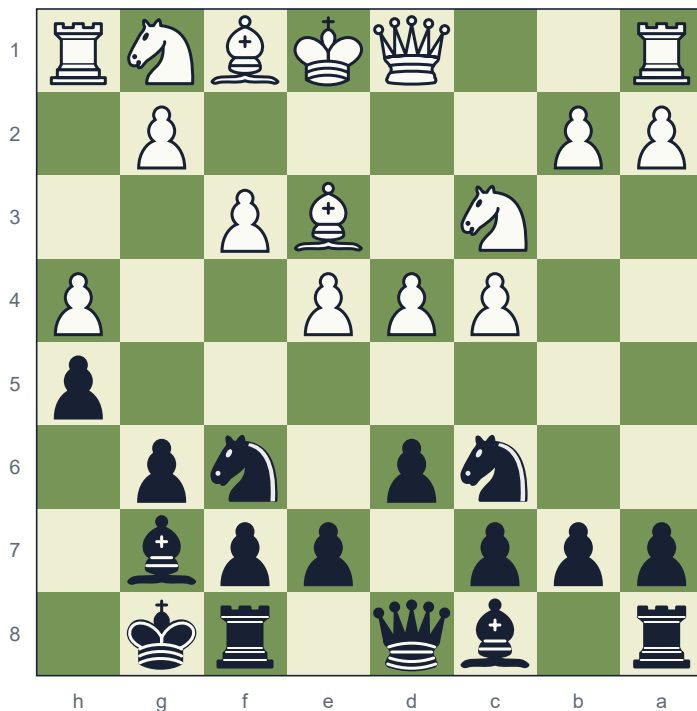
THINK BEFORE MOVING

What would change your decision between ...b5 and ...e5?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

Samisch: defending the king without passivity



White to move | from 10-04

DIAGNOSE

The h-pawns face one another after ...h5. The h-file is closed for now, but White can create a new lever with g4.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Finish development and create central or queenside counterplay. Defend forcing threats directly. Keep a defender near g6 and avoid unnecessary dark-square weaknesses.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may play g4, sacrifice on h5, or exchange the g7 bishop with Bh6. A blocked h-file is not permanent safety.

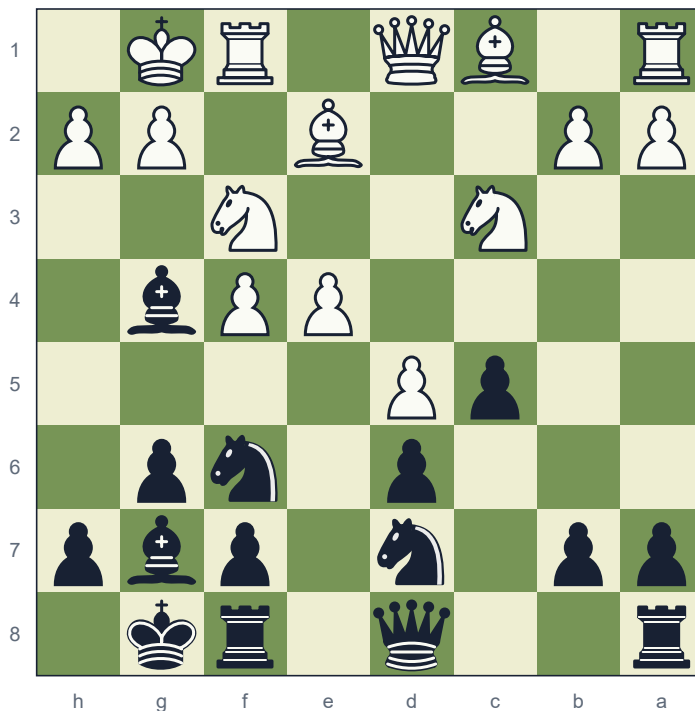
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Which new pawn lever attacks h5, and what active counterplay can Black prepare?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

Benoni structure against the Four Pawns



White to move | from 11-01

DIAGNOSE

White has a d5 wedge and an e4/f4 center; Black has d6 and c5. Black's e-pawn has been exchanged, opening the e-file.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Pressure e4, challenge the knight that supports e5, and develop rapidly. Prepare queenside expansion only when d6 and the king are secure.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White threatens e5 with tempo or a kingside attack. A passive setup lets the space advantage grow.

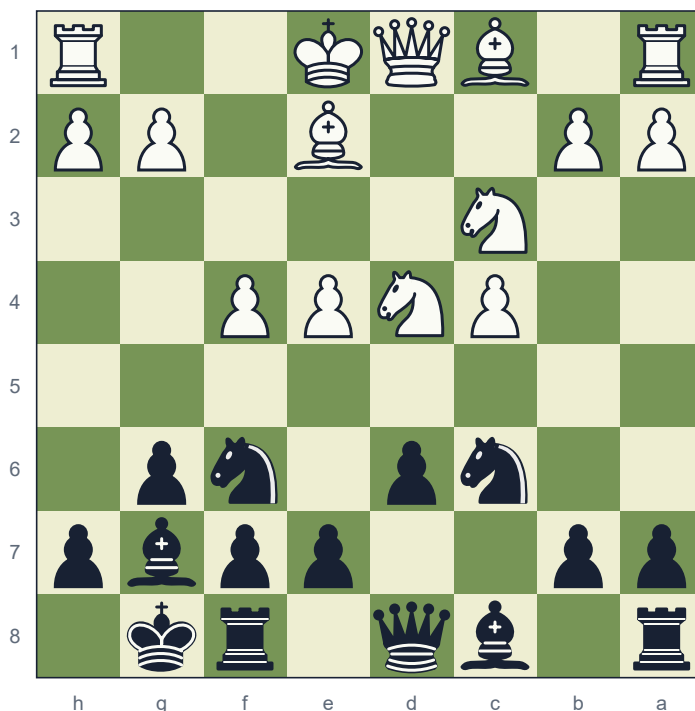
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Which white piece supports e5, and why is exchanging it potentially useful?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

The central bind after ...cxd4



White to move | from 11-02

DIAGNOSE

White's d-pawn has disappeared. Pawns on c4 and e4 control d5, restricting Black's central break.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Develop toward a supported ...d5 or create useful queenside pressure. Trade a pair of pieces when it reduces the cramp without conceding a permanent weakness.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White can maintain the bind, improve pieces and attack d6. An unsupported ...d5 may simply lose a pawn.

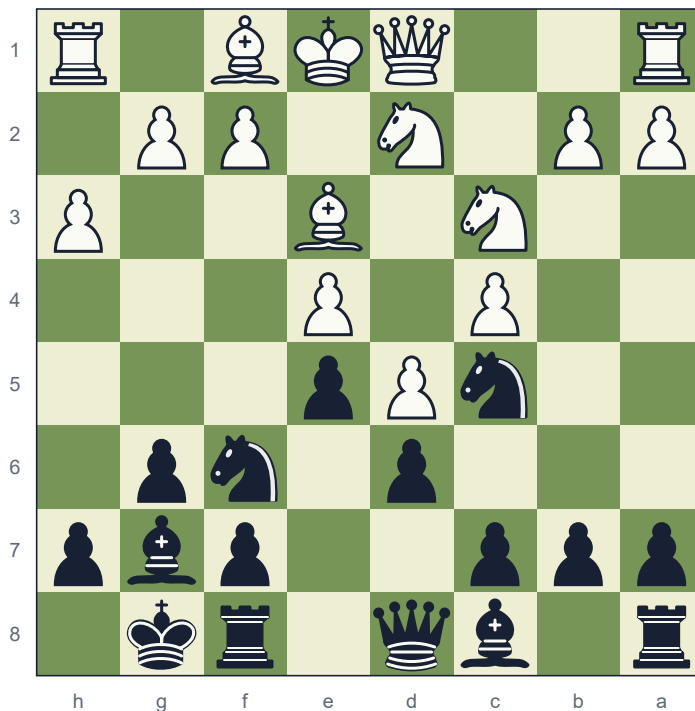
THINK BEFORE MOVING

What preparation would make ...d5 a freeing break rather than a pawn sacrifice?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

Makogonov: restraint before attack



Black to move | from 13-01

DIAGNOSE

h3 restrains g4 and supports a possible g4 advance. The c5 knight gives Black activity but can be challenged by b4.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Coordinate pieces behind the center. Compare ...a5, ...c6 and a prepared ...f5; choose according to White's king and the knight's safety.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White can attack on the kingside while delaying castling, or gain queenside space against Nc5.

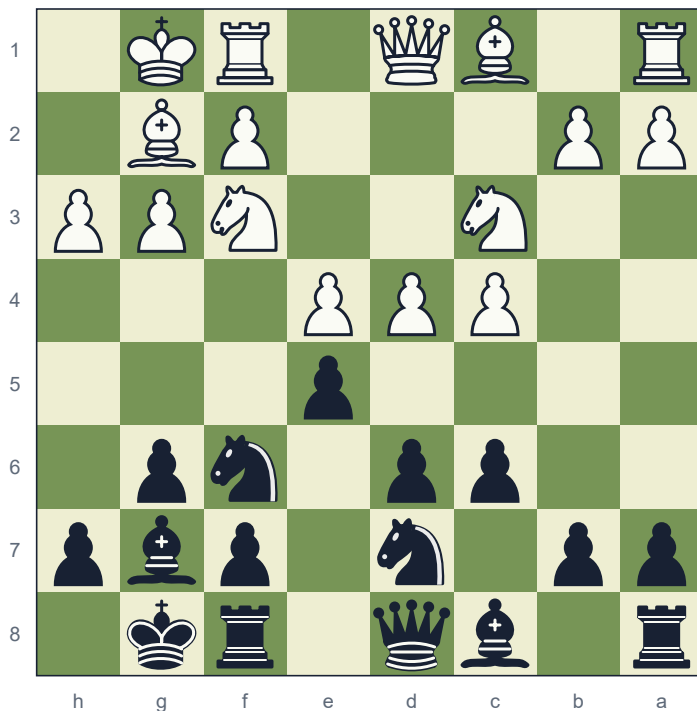
THINK BEFORE MOVING

What information about White's king do you need before launching a pawn storm?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

Fianchetto: pressure through the center



Black to move | from 14-01

DIAGNOSE

Both kings have fianchettoed bishops. White's g2 bishop adds a defender and a long-range attacker, changing the value of a kingside pawn advance.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Develop central pressure with ...Re8, ...exd4 and a knight on c5 when justified. ...c6 can support a later ...d5 break.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White may open the long diagonal with a central exchange. An exposed b7 pawn or loose c6 piece can then become a target.

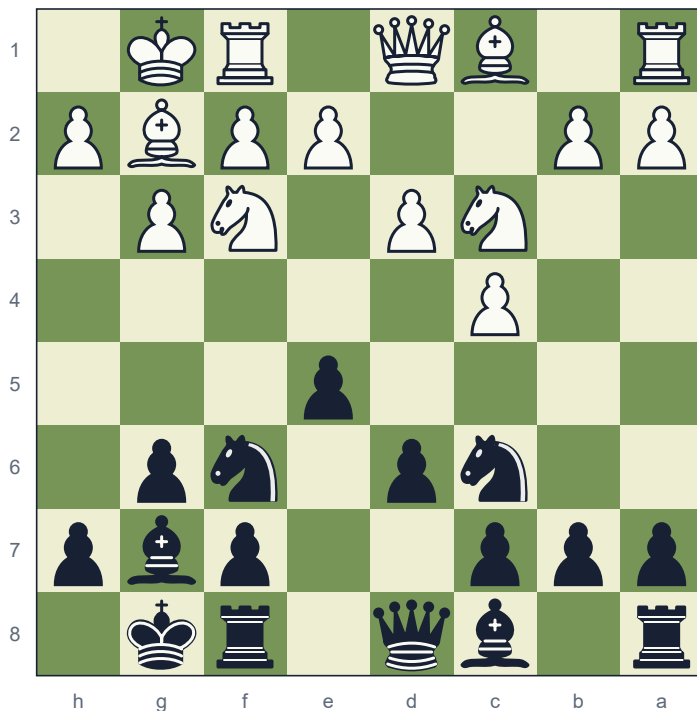
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Which central exchange activates the g2 bishop, and what must Black recheck afterward?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

English: no d4 wedge



White to move | from 18-03

DIAGNOSE

White uses d3 rather than d4. Black's e5 foothold controls d4, and there is no locked d5/e4 chain.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Develop the queen bishop and consider a well-supported ...d5. Watch queenside expansion and use central squares for pieces.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White can play Rb1/b4, f4, or d4 later. Each advance changes which pawn break is most relevant.

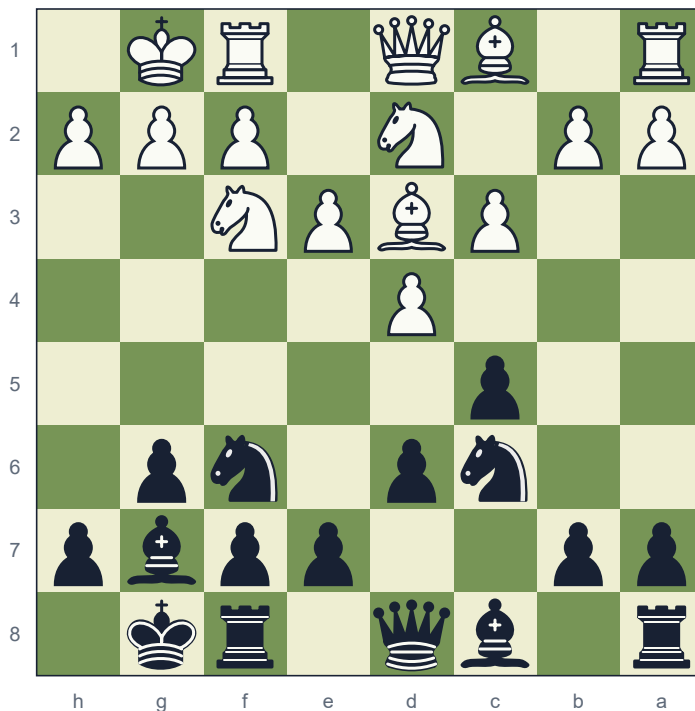
THINK BEFORE MOVING

Why is a routine Mar del Plata kingside race inappropriate in this diagram?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.

System openings: stop a free e4 break



White to move | from 19-04

DIAGNOSE

White has a compact d4/e3 center and Bd3. Black attacks d4 with ...c5 and develops against the coming e4 advance.

YOUR BLACK PLAN

Increase central pressure with ...Nc6 and useful bishop development. Resolve the pawn tension only when the resulting structure helps you.

WHITE'S COUNTERPLAY

White can prepare e4 with Nbd2 and Re1. If the center opens, Bd3 may create threats toward h7.

THINK BEFORE MOVING

What is White's intended central break, and which black pieces should contest it?

PRACTICE

Write two candidate moves and calculate White's most forcing reply to each. Then choose the move that improves your position without giving away the opponent's immediate resource.